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UAE draws 37% of regional FDI inflows

DUBAI
BY KHITAM AL AMIR
Chief News Editor

Foreign direct investment (FDI) flows into the UAE surged to Dh167 billion (\$45 billion) last year, marking a 48 per cent increase compared to the previous year, according to the latest report by the United Nations Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD).

His Highness Shaikh Mohammad Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, said, "The UAE accounted for 37 per cent of total FDI flows into the region, meaning that for every \$100 of foreign investment entering the region, \$37 was directed to the UAE. This underscores the country's growing appeal as a global hub for business, innovation, and investment."

Second globally

Globally, the UAE ranked second only to the US in the number of new FDI projects launched last year.

"The UAE has set an ambitious target of attracting Dh1.3 trillion in FDI over the next six years. We have a clear development agenda set forth by President His Highness Shaikh Mohammad Bin Zayed Al Nahyan, and driven by a unified, dedicated team aligned with his directives. Our people are united around their leadership — and this is the key to our success," Shaikh Mohammad Bin Rashid added.

Iran, Europe try diplomacy as US weighs joining Israel's fight

IRAN FOREIGN MINISTER TO MEET COUNTERPARTS FROM GERMANY, FRANCE, UK

VIENNA

Iran's foreign minister will meet in Geneva today with counterparts from Germany, France and the UK, Iranian state media and European diplomats said, as Israeli airstrikes target his country's nuclear and military sites and Iran fires back.

Europe's push for diplomacy is in sharp contrast to messages from Washington, with US President Donald Trump openly weighing bombing Iran and calling for the unconditional surrender of the Iranian leadership.

Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi will travel to Geneva for the meetings today, the state-run IRNA news agency reported. European diplomats, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss the confidential talks, confirmed the meetings.

"All sides must show restraint, refrain from taking steps which lead to further escalation in the region, and return to diplomacy," read a joint statement issued Wednesday by France, Germany, the UK and the EU.

Lasting solution

"The EU will continue to contribute to all diplomatic efforts to reduce tensions and to find a lasting solution to the Iranian nuclear issue, which can only be through a negotiated deal," said Anouar El Anouni, a spokesperson for the European Commission.

Today's meeting in Geneva could also provide the three



Indian students wait to board a flight from Armenia to New Delhi, under India's Operation Sindhu, amid the Israel-Iran conflict, yesterday.
ANI

European nations with a unique opportunity to reach out to Iran in what is going to be the first face-to-face meeting between Western officials and Tehran since the start of the conflict a week ago.

Meanwhile, British Prime Minister Keir Starmer called on Trump to keep the door open to talks over Iran's nuclear programme, in the clearest sign yet of the UK leader's concern about possible American military action against the country.

"The nuclear issue has to be dealt with, but it's better dealt with by way of negotiation than

by way of conflict and therefore our clear objective here is to de-escalate the situation," Starmer told broadcasters yesterday. "There have been several rounds of discussions with the US. That, to me, is the way to resolve this issue."

Russia warns US

Russia's foreign ministry also warned the US not to take military action against Iran. "We would like to particularly warn Washington against military intervention in the situation, which would be an extremely dangerous step with

truly unpredictable negative consequences," the ministry's spokeswoman Maria Zakharova told reporters.

UK's Secretary of State for Foreign and Commonwealth Affairs David Lammy flew to Washington yesterday to meet US Secretary of State Marco Rubio. The US may want to use the UK-controlled base on Diego Garcia in the Indian Ocean in a potential strike on Iran's underground nuclear facility at Fordow but is not believed to have requested to do so yet.

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Google tools helped add Dh21.8b to UAE's economy last year

Dh20.2b came from businesses using Google Search, Ads

DUBAI
BY JUSTIN VARGHESE
Your Money Editor

A new report released this week shows that Google's tools and services added a whopping Dh21.8 billion to the UAE economy in 2024 alone. Of that, Dh20.2 billion came from businesses using Google Search and Ads to reach customers and grow faster.

That's the takeaway from the latest Google Economic Impact Report, conducted by research firm Public First. The Android and Google Play app

HOW GOOGLE TOOLS' USAGE ADDS UP IN UAE

- 90% said mobile payment tools like Google Pay make life easier.
- 89% use Maps or Waze to avoid getting lost.
- 63% have tried Gemini, Google's AI assistant — and most found it boosted their productivity.
- 71% said Gemini was easier to use in Arabic compared to other AI bots.
- 94% of adults in the UAE use Google Search at least once a month to compare prices.
- 86% check Google reviews before deciding where to go.
- 80% use Maps or Waze to find local businesses.
- 91% of companies say they're now using at least one AI tool in their daily operations. —J. V.

ecosystem also helped support 30,000 jobs in 2024, and developers in the UAE earned around Dh455 million in revenue through apps and services.

According to the report, the average person in the UAE gets around Dh683 worth of monthly value from using Google services.

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